

1. Frequent Size Exchanges

What to check

Track:

Total size exchanges

÷

Total orders

Example:

10 orders

6 size exchanges

Important

Size exchange itself is NOT fraud.

A genuine customer may buy M and exchange for L.

The suspicious pattern is:

Buy S

Exchange M

Buy M

Exchange L

Buy S + M + L

Keep L

Return S + M

Suggested scoring

Normal size exchanges → 0

Repeated → +5

Very frequent → +10

Extreme pattern → +15

Action

Usually **Medium risk**, not immediate rejection.

Request proof only when combined with other suspicious signals.

2. Multiple Sizes in One Order

What to check

Detect whether the customer orders:

Same product:

S

M

L

XL

and later returns most of them.

Example

Product: T-Shirt

S → returned

M → returned

L → kept

XL → returned

Why?

This can indicate "try multiple sizes and return the rest."

But this can also be completely legitimate.

Score

2 sizes $\rightarrow$ 0

3 sizes $\rightarrow$ +5

4+ sizes $\rightarrow$ +10

Repeated pattern $\rightarrow$ +15

Action

Don't restrict based on one order.

Restrict/proof should happen only if this pattern repeatedly occurs.

3. Repeated Size Switching

This is different from #1.

Example

Order 1: M $\rightarrow$ L

Order 2: L $\rightarrow$ M

Order 3: M $\rightarrow$ L

Order 4: L $\rightarrow$ M

Why?

Repeated switching may indicate unusual ordering behavior.

Score

1–2 exchanges $\rightarrow$ 0

3 exchanges $\rightarrow$ +5

4–5 $\rightarrow$ +10

6+ $\rightarrow$ +15

Action

Usually:

Medium → Manual Review

Don't reject automatically.

4. Wardrobing Pattern

This is one of your most important checkpoints.

What is wardrobing?

Customer buys clothing, uses/wears it and then returns it.

The system cannot reliably determine "worn" from order data alone, so don't claim that the algorithm knows the customer wore it.

Instead, identify **patterns that warrant inspection**.

Example:

Customer repeatedly buys premium clothing

↓

Returns after several days

↓

Claims "changed mind"

↓

High number of fashion returns

↓

Previous condition issues

Score

Pattern detected → +20

Repeated pattern → +30

Previous condition issues → +35

Action

Proof required / manual inspection

This is a case where I would **not auto-reject** based solely on the score.

5. High-Value Item Returns

What to check

Compare return value with customer's normal order value.

Example:

Normal orders: ₹800–₹2,000

Current return: ₹15,000

Why?

A sudden high-value return deserves more verification.

Score

Normal value → 0

2× normal → +5

3× normal → +10

5×+ normal → +15

Action

Medium risk → manual/proof review.

6. Return Immediately After Delivery

What to check

Time between:

Delivered



Return requested

Example:

Delivered: 10:00 AM

Return: 10:15 AM

Important

This is **not necessarily suspicious**.

Maybe the customer immediately discovered the wrong size.

Score

Normal → 0

Very quick → +5

Repeated immediate returns → +10

Action

Never restrict based only on this checkpoint.

Combine with other signals.

7. Return Near Policy Deadline

Example:

Your store has a:

7-day return policy

Customer repeatedly requests returns on:

Day 7

Day 7

Day 6

Day 7

Why?

Repeated last-day returns can be a pattern worth investigating.

Score

Occasional → 0

Repeated → +5

Strong repeated pattern → +10

Action

Usually **Medium risk**.

8. Same Product Repeatedly Returned

Example:

Customer purchases Product A

→ returns

Purchases Product A

→ returns

Purchases Product A

→ returns

Why?

Could indicate:

- Product problem
- Wrong sizing
- Quality issue
- Customer behavior

You need to distinguish between these.

Important improvement

Check whether **other customers are also returning that product**.

If 70% of customers return the same product, the problem may be the **product**, not the customer.

Score

2 returns → +5

3 → +10

4+ → +15

9. Frequent Damage Claims

What to check

Count claims such as:

Damaged product

Broken product

Torn product

Scratched product

Used product

Example:

10 returns

5 damage claims

Score

0–1 → 0

2 → +5

3 → +15

4+ → +25

Action

Repeated damage claims should trigger **proof requirement**.

10. Damage Claim Without Evidence

Suppose the merchant requires:

Photo of damaged product

Customer repeatedly says:

"Product was damaged"

but doesn't provide evidence.

Score

First time → 0

Repeated missing evidence → +10

Multiple claims without evidence → +20

Action

Request photo/video proof.

Don't immediately reject.

11. Return Reason Inconsistency

Example:

Customer initially says:

"Wrong size"

Then later:

"Product damaged"

Then:

"Product quality issue"

Why?

Changing reasons doesn't automatically mean fraud, but it can increase uncertainty.

Score

Consistent → 0

One change → +5

Repeated changes → +10

Major contradictions → +15

Action

Manual review.

12. Frequent Address Changes

What to check

Track:

Customer A

Order 1 → Address A

Order 2 → Address B

Order 3 → Address C

Order 4 → Address D

Why?

Frequent changes may be suspicious, but they can also happen because people travel or move.

Score

Normal → 0

2–3 changes → +5

4–5 → +10

6+ → +15

Action

Use as a **supporting signal**, never as the only reason for restriction.

13. Multiple Accounts With Same Identity Signals

Suppose:

Account A

Phone → X

Address → Y

Account B

Phone → X

Address → Y

What to check

Potential shared signals:

- Phone
- Email
- Address
- Payment identifier
- Device/browser signals, if legally and appropriately collected

Why?

Multiple accounts may be used to bypass customer-level restrictions.

Score

2 related accounts → +10

3+ → +20

Repeated suspicious behavior → +30

Action

Manual investigation.

14. High Refund-to-Order Ratio

Calculate:

Total refunded amount

Total purchase amount

Example:

Purchased = ₹50,000

Refunded = ₹35,000

Refund ratio = 70%

Score

<20% → 0

20–40% → +5

40–60% → +15

60%+ → +25

Why?

A customer receiving refunds for most purchases deserves additional review.

15. Seasonal Return Behavior

This is an interesting feature for your project.

Example:

Wedding season



Customer buys ethnic wear



After event



Returns everything

But you need historical data.

Example

Customer:

Jan → normal

Feb → normal

Mar → normal

Apr → 5 ethnic-wear returns

Score

Slight seasonal anomaly → +5

Strong anomaly → +10

Repeated seasonal pattern → +20

Action

Usually **Medium/High**, requiring supporting signals.

16. Previous Rejected Return

Suppose:

Return 1 → Rejected

Return 2 → Approved

Return 3 → Rejected

Return 4 → New return

Why?

Repeated rejected claims are an important historical signal.

Score

1 rejected → +5

2 → +10

3 → +20

4+ → +25

Action

New return should generally go to:

Manual Review / Proof Required

rather than automatic approval.

17. Unusual Order Quantity

Example:

Normally:

Customer orders 1–2 items

Suddenly:

Customer orders 15 identical products

Then:

Returns 14

Why?

This can indicate unusual behavior.

But it could also be a legitimate bulk purchase.

Score

2× normal quantity → +5

3× → +10

5×+ → +20

Large quantity + high return → +30

17. Product/Serial Number Mismatch ★★ ★

This is a **very important missing checkpoint**.

For electronics, mobiles, laptops, watches, appliances, etc., store a product identifier when the order is shipped:

Order:

Product: iPhone

Serial/IMEI: ABC123456

When the return arrives:

Returned item:

Serial/IMEI: XYZ987654

If they don't match:

HIGH/CRITICAL RISK

Flipkart explicitly says return pickup validation can check the product's IMEI, name, image, brand, serial number, article number and barcode.

This can detect **switch fraud**, where someone returns a different/older/damaged item instead of the item originally purchased.

18. Missing Accessories / Incomplete Product

Check whether the returned package contains everything originally shipped.

For example:

Original order:

Laptop

Charger

Mouse

Manual

Bag

Returned:

Laptop

Charger

✗ Mouse

✗ Bag

Your system should compare:

Original package contents



Returned package contents

Flipkart explicitly includes accessories, manuals, freebies and combo items in its return-condition checks.

Return Guard action

Missing accessory



Calculate accessory value



Minor → Partial refund / manual review

Major → Hold refund

This is particularly useful for **electronics and bundles**.

19. Product Condition / Tampered Seal Check

Your current system talks about "damage", but you should separate:

- Damaged
- Used
- Washed
- Soiled
- Scratched
- Seal broken
- Warranty seal tampered
- Return tag removed

Flipkart explicitly checks whether products are unused, unwashed, unsoiled and whether applicable quality/return/warranty seals remain intact.

So add:

CONDITION_CHECK

with values:

UNUSED

USED

DAMAGED

SOILED

TAMPERED

UNKNOWN

Example

Customer says:

"Product damaged."

Pickup inspection finds:

Product is used

Return tag removed

Visible stains

That should substantially increase risk.

20. Packaging / Box Mismatch ★★

Check:

Original packaging



Returned packaging

For example:

Original:

Samsung box + seal

Returned:

Different box / damaged box

This is especially useful for electronics.

Flipkart's published return checks include original packaging condition.

Score

Minor packaging damage → +5

Major damage → +10

Wrong packaging → +20

21. Wrong Item Returned / Product Swap

This should be one of your **highest-priority rules**.

Example:

Customer purchased:

Nike Shoe

₹8,000

Returned:

Different shoe

₹2,000

or:

Original product → new

Returned product → old/damaged

Your system can compare:

SKU

Barcode

Serial number

IMEI

Product image

Brand

Model

Color

Size

This is one of the major forms of return fraud discussed in the industry, and current return-fraud technology is also using item images/authenticity checks to detect swaps.

Decision

Immediate HOLD + Manual Verification

Don't auto-refund.

22. Return Quantity Mismatch

Suppose the customer ordered:

5 products

but requests:

return = 5

and only sends back:

4

Your system should detect:

Ordered Quantity: 5

Return Quantity: 5

Received Quantity: 4

Action

Refund eligible quantity = 4

Missing item = investigation

This is especially important for bulk orders and bundles.

23. Duplicate Return / Multiple Return Requests

This is another important one.

Example:

Order #1234

Return request #1 → submitted

Return request #2 → submitted

Return request #3 → submitted

Or:

Customer requests return

↓

Cancels

↓

Requests again

↓

Cancels

↓

Requests again

This should increase risk.

Score

1 request → 0

2 requests → +10

3+ requests → +20

24. One-Time vs Repeated Replacement

Flipkart's published policy shows that certain categories may allow only one replacement.

So your system should track:

Replacement count per order

Example:

Replacement #1 → approved

Replacement #2 → requested

Then:

Manual review

This prevents endless replacement cycles.

25. Open-Box / Delivery-Time Verification

This is a **very interesting checkpoint for India**.

Some deliveries may involve open-box verification.

For example:

Delivery

↓

Customer checks product



Product appears correct



Customer accepts

If a customer later claims:

"Wrong product delivered"

your system should know whether the order was accepted after an open-box check.

Flipkart's published policy specifically describes open-box delivery and says that after acceptance, returns may be restricted except for certain defects.

Your data model could store:

open_box_delivery = true

customer_accepted = true

delivery_verification = passed

Then:

Later wrong-product claim



Higher scrutiny

But don't automatically reject—there can still be legitimate defects.

26. Category/Product-Specific Return Eligibility

This is **extremely important**.

Your current scoring system treats all returns similarly.

Don't.

A:

T-shirt

and:

Mobile phone

shouldn't have the same return rules.

Flipkart's current policy has different windows/actions by category—for example, some lifestyle items have refund/replacement/exchange options, while many electronics have replacement/service-center processes and some products are non-returnable.

So create:

ReturnPolicy

with:

category

return_window

refund_allowed

replacement_allowed

exchange_allowed

proof_required

inspection_required

non_returnable

Then your scoring engine knows:

"This particular return isn't even eligible for normal auto-approval."

27. Customer Return Rate vs Product Return Rate

This is one of my favorite additions.

Suppose:

Product A

Store return rate = 60%

Customer return rate = 65%

Don't flag the customer heavily.

The product itself may have a sizing/quality problem.

But:

Product return rate = 10%

Customer return rate = 75%

Now the customer's behavior is much more unusual.

So calculate:

Customer Return Rate

VS

Product Return Rate

VS

Category Return Rate

This will make your system **much smarter**.

28. First-Time Customer vs Long-Term Customer

Add customer tenure.

Example:

Customer A

Customer for 3 years

100 orders

5 returns

Customer B

Customer for 10 days

5 orders

4 returns

Both may have similar recent activity, but their historical context is different.

So include:

customer_age

total_orders

successful_orders

successful_deliveries

return_history

A long-term customer with one unusual return shouldn't be treated the same as a brand-new account with extreme behavior.

extreme behavior.

A very important Points

After researching the marketplace approach, there are **4 types of checks**.

This will make your project much more professional.

Type A — Eligibility Checks

These happen **before risk scoring**.

Is product returnable?

Is return within window?

Is category eligible?

Is refund allowed?

Is replacement allowed?

If no:

Return not eligible according to policy.

Type B — Product Verification

Then verify the actual returned product:

SKU

Barcode

Serial number

IMEI

Brand

Model

Quantity

Accessories

Packaging

Seals

Condition

Product image

This catches:

Wrong product / product swap / missing components / used product.

Type C — Customer Behavior Risk

Then run your original behavioral checks:

Return frequency

COD refusal

Size switching

Multiple sizes

Damage claims

Wrong-product claims

Address patterns

Multiple accounts

Previous rejected claims

Refund ratio

Seasonal behavior

etc.

Type D — Decision Engine

Finally:

Eligibility

+

Product Verification

+

Customer Risk

+

Historical Comparison

↓

Final Decision